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# Global AI Trend Tracker

Global Markets Research
22 October 2026

EQUITY: TECHNOLOGY

## META's 3Q26 earnings read through

## Quick Note


**Research Analysts**

China Technology

**Bing Duan - NIHK**
bing.duan1@nomura.com
+852 2252 2141

**Joel Ying, CFA - NIHK**
joel.ying@nomura.com
+852 2252 2153


META (META US, Not rated) reported its 3Q26 earnings on 21 October 2026 after the US market close, and on the same day, management hosted an analyst briefing. Management mainly discussed its AI products and services development, monetization progress, AI product portfolios and long-term AI strategy. The company's **FY26E capex guidance remained largely unchanged at USD135-145bn** (previously USD130-145bn), while management expects **continuous substantial investment** beyond 2026E. Regarding the computing power, Meta is investing aggressively in capacity while improving inference efficiency and using multiple channels to monetize the resulting compute. We think this indicates the company's continued commitment to investing in frontier models and Generative AI applications. We like global optical transceiver leader Zhongji Innolight (300308 CH / 3308 HK, Buy), and major PCB / CCL suppliers such as WUS (002463 CH, Buy, covered by Anne Lee), which could benefit from continued global AI infrastructure investment.

### 3Q26 core business performance

- META reported 26.1% y-y revenue growth for 3Q26, beating the Bloomberg consensus estimate by 2%, and delivered a 264.0% y-y increase in earnings to USD9.9bn, beating the consensus by 7%. For 4Q26E, management **guided for USD73-76bn in total revenue**, with foreign currency providing ~1% headwind to y-y growth.
- **Family of Apps ad revenue** was USD63.1bn, up 26% y-y, driven by increased total number of ad impressions served (+10% y-y) and increased average price per ad (+14% y-y). **Reality Labs** segment revenue was USD443mn in 3Q26, down 6% y-y due to lower Quest headset sales.
- **Capex (purchase of PP&E) increased 80.3% y-y and 12.7% q-q in 3Q26 to USD33.9bn,** while **capex including principal payments for finance leases was USD34.9bn,** driven by investments in servers, data centers, and network infrastructure.
- **Management expects 2026E capex including principal payments for finance leases to be in the range of USD135-145bn, narrowing from its prior estimate of USD130-145bn.** Meta plans to **continue substantial investment** beyond 2026E to support model training, core-business growth, new AI products, and additional infrastructure capacity.

### AI development and monetization progress

- Management stated that **Llama 4** is at or near the state of the art across several dimensions relevant to personal super-intelligence, reinforcing the value of proprietary model development.
- Meta plans to advance the frontier of intelligence while distilling larger models into smaller, more efficient models optimized for personal agents.
- Family of Apps is now used by 3.64bn people each day.
- Management reported that more than **10mn** people in the United States and Canada had set up its personal super-intelligence product.
- The leading use cases of **Muse** include shopping, personal productivity, and creative creation; more than **25% of weekly active users** were reported to use shopping

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functionality.

- Meta began migrating **content-understanding models** to internally developed models and reported an approximately 80% reduction in per-item content-processing costs within relevant systems.
- **Meta AI Business Assistant** is being positioned as a more proactive partner for advertisers. Management estimated that advertisers adopting its recommendations achieved nearly 5% more conversions at unchanged cost per conversion and increased advertising budgets by approximately 9% compared with similar advertisers that did not adopt the recommendations.
- Nearly **10mn advertisers** used at least one generative AI creative tools during the quarter, while use of video-generation tools increased sequentially.
- On the compute side, Meta is building out the capacity to serve more than a billion people over the next few years.
- Management stated that **Muse** is very compute-intensive to run, and will improve its cost efficiency by more than 10x in the next year, which will enable it to be profitable once the revenue lines are at scale.
- Management stated Meta is building several **new AI businesses** and expects these to begin **contributing incremental revenue in 2027E**, through subscriptions, transactions, advertising, and developing enterprise offerings.

## AI strategy and capital allocation

- The **personal agent** is expected to become more deeply integrated across Meta's ecosystem, including Meta's core applications, messaging services, smart glasses, and other hardware, according to the management.
- Meta's longer-term objective is to build an interconnected "**agent network**," rather than a standalone consumer assistant. Personal agents would interact with business agents and other agents to create more useful experiences.
- **Meta Enterprise Platform** is intended to create multiple high-margin distribution channels for Meta's models, including APIs, coding products, and other enterprise services in addition to consumer applications.
- Meta plans to create a **new class of non-voting capital stock**, which will be distributed to all existing shareholders through a stock dividend. For each existing share held, stockholders will receive one share of the new non-voting stock, effectively resulting in a two-for-one stock split. Management expects trading to begin in late January 2027.

**Fig. 1: META – 3Q26 financial summary**

| Unit: USD mn | 3Q26 actual | 3Q26E | Actual vs BBG Cons | 4Q26E Guidance |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Revenue | 64,601 | 63,323 | 2% | 73~76bn |
| y-y % | 26.1% | 23.6% | | 22%~27% |
| q-q % | 6.2% | 5.1% | | |
| Gross Profit | 51,232 | 50,746 | 1% | |
| Gross margin % | 79.3% | 80.1% | | |
| Operating profit | 12,988 | 11,587 | 12% | |
| Operating margin % | 20.1% | 18.3% | | |
| Net profit | 9,860 | 9,190 | 7% | |
| Net margin % | 15.3% | 14.5% | | |

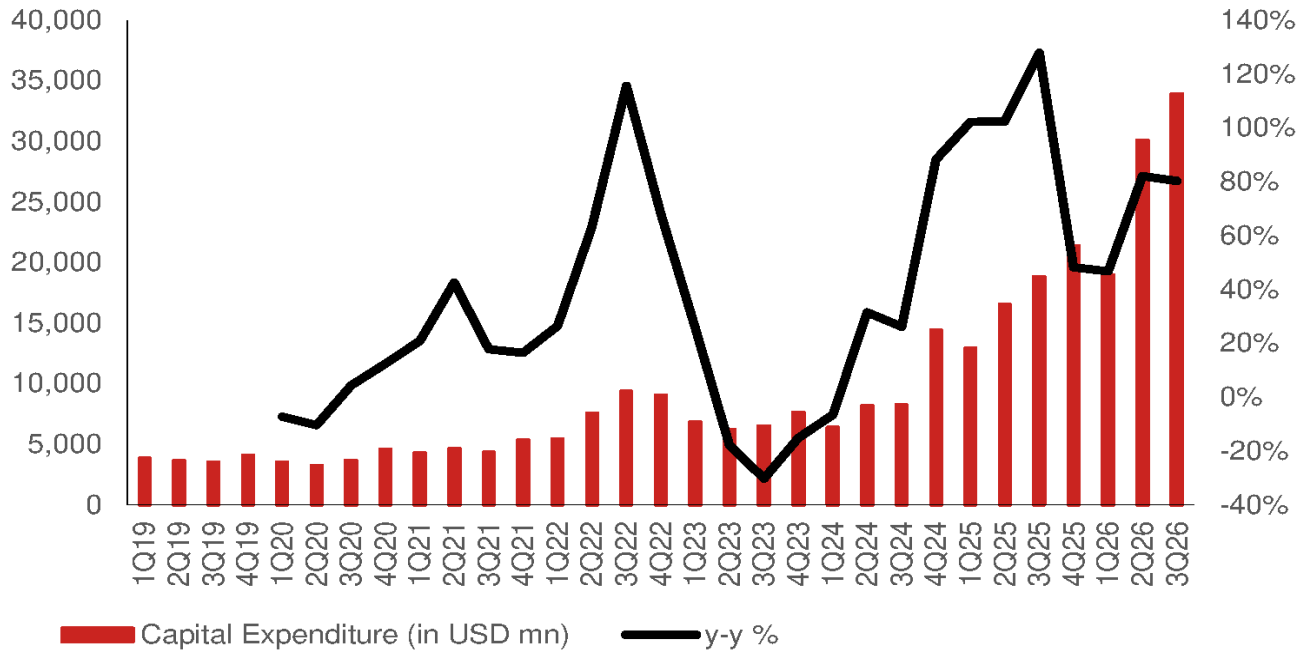
Source: Company data, Bloomberg Finance L.P., Nomura research

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**Fig. 2: META – quarterly capex trend**




Source: Bloomberg Finance L.P., Nomura research



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# Appendix A-1

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